Chapter 1: Sunshine and Rainbows

"Coffee?" she asked.

"No.... Can I have you instead?" he responded.

The two chuckled; their eyes locked with one another as they lay in each other's arms.

"I am yours."

"And I am yours."

"All of you?"

"All of me. Completely, entirely, and fully." Their lips locked together after finishing his sentence, sealing the sentence and the promise.

They held each other firmly as one's lips lingered over the other. Joseph was whole here. It was a feeling he had always ignored. He never knew how complete he was here. After softly kissing his wife good morning, he gave her a peck and then another. He was in love, and he was grateful it was Imaani that he was in love with. She chuckled at the storm of pecks she received, squirming as they rolled around in their massive bed.

Finally, after all that struggle of trying to get her husband off her, she managed to get up, making Joseph groan and pout like a child. He didn't want to start his day just yet, despite it being twelve in the afternoon. It was a Sunday, and everything was so peaceful. All he wanted to do was spend today in bed with her. They didn't have to work today, there was nothing on their to-do list, and they weren't expecting any guests either. The afternoon was all clear to facilitate anything, provided, of course, that Joseph had forgotten about a promise he made.

"We have to get up," she responded, smiling down at him.

"But I want more time with you, and it's a Sunday. Come back," he whined, reaching his hand out for her to grab.

"We have all the time in the world now. Also, did you forget?" she raised a brow.

With his eyes shut, Joseph furrowed his brow, trying to think about what he had forgotten.

“You promised your little creation that we would go to the beach,” Imaani scoffed, jokingly pulling the covers off of Joseph.

Another groan escaped Joseph’s mouth as he lazily sat up. “Our little creation,” he corrected as he rubbed his eyes.

Imaani lightly laughed and ruffled his hair, wrapping her arms around him. Their eyes met once again. It was never enough. Their hearts fluttered like it was the first time they had felt such adoration for one another. Joseph’s fingers lingered over her arm, feeling her soft chocolate skin under his touch. Her hands found his as they entangled themselves with his fingers.

“I adore you more and more every day,” Joseph whispered in his groggy voice, not breaking eye contact.

The room was filled with their love. It was hard not to notice how powerful the essence of their existence was when they were together.

“I have always adored you,” replied Imaani.

The two leaned in for another kiss. Their affection for one another wasn’t mere love; it exceeded this word on all accounts. What they actually felt was adoration, and the feeling burned with intensity. In their mind, while love represented a desire toward someone based on a single trait, adoration meant that they accepted each other whole. One could ‘love’ multiple people at the same time, but one could only adore a few within their lifetime. And what they had wasn’t *just* love; it was more. It was different. It was everything and anything. And that’s what mattered; the two of them, living together and looking after their little bundle of joy in a beautiful house in the Suburbs.

It was hard to believe they had been married for over three years now, mainly because of their soft gaze. Most marriages would run their course by this time, but not theirs. Their love language dripped like honey through various gestures, from touch to sight. It remained constant. Even when they fought now, they knew they wanted to stay. They *chose* one another.

Both finally got out of bed and decided to begin their day. They brushed their teeth side by side in their marble bathroom. Joseph looked at Imaani through the mirror; he could never stop. His soft gaze lingered all over her, evidence of how he could never get enough of her. Such emotions oozed out of him quite often these past four years. Most of them he’d say it out loud, but some of them he’d hold back.

Imaani stood in front of the mirror. She zoned out for a while, something that would happen often. It was involuntary. She went to visit places in her head that she never wanted to.

Noticing her mental occupation, Joseph accompanied her. He rubbed her arms and kissed her shoulder, a gesture he made every time such an event occurred.

Things had changed. Joseph had changed. He would do anything and everything for her. Yet, sometimes, her mind couldn't help it and wandered off, which Joseph didn't mind. He was patient. After one last kiss, Joseph finally left the room to pack everyone's things.

Imaani went to wake their son, Mathew. He was a perfect mix of the two. He had his mother's light curly hair and his father's brown eyes that resembled the color of honey under the sun. He had a perfect buttoned nose, and his complexion was perfectly tan, which he inherited from Joseph. Their 'little creation,' as they liked to call it, was very sleepy. He yawned and hugged his mother.

"Beach day," he said, in the softest voice with the widest and laziest smile.

"Beach day," Imaani nodded, chuckling as she moved some of his messy curls out of Mathew's face.

Imaani picked him up and took him to his bathroom. The blue tiles distracted her four-year-old while he was given a quick bath by his mother. She helped him brush his teeth and used hair-product on his curls. Imaani then went to the drawer with her son in her arms, wrapped in a baby-blue towel.

"Red... green... or blue?!" Imaani said as she pointed out the different selection of shorts that hung in his closet.

The whole room was designed in shades of blue, with minimalistic furniture. It was spacious and had everything a child could ever want; a treasure chest with all kinds of toys, a small train track set near the window, and a shelf with his learning books.

Mathew pointed at the pair of blue shorts. "Blue!" He giggled.

"Yes! Very good! Blue!" Imaani squealed, wiggling him in her arms in excitement.

Mathew was given a plain white shirt by his mother, and she helped him put it on and then took him to the kitchen with her. Once there, she had her coffee and gave him a sandwich. Meanwhile, Joseph had kept all the things they needed for the beach in the trunk of their well-kept Cadillac, one of the many vintage cars they owned. He double-checked the bags he stored inside. They had the usual, umbrellas, towels, 'the sand castle tool kit' as Imaani called it, snacks, lotion, sunblock, extra clothes for the three of them, and, finally, sunglasses. Joseph wore a pair of black shorts and a teal button-down with the top three buttons open. He hopped into his car and pulled it out of the driveway, his car pointing in the direction they wanted to set off in.

After five minutes of waiting, Joseph honked twice, eager to go to the beach now too. While he waited, his mind began to wander. It revisited various sets of memories like the time he was in high school, how college went, and much more in mere minutes. That was the thing about the human mind; it tended to wander and sometimes trespassed into places that didn't wish to come near. Joseph felt slight unease, but he couldn't pull himself out of it. The imagery of those memories was too vivid.

"Mathew, no running!" Joseph heard Imaani shout.

His train of thoughts came to a halt as he looked up from the steering wheel and gazed at his four-year-old running to the car with the brightest smile. Joseph lightly smiled as his gaze averted to his wife, who was walking to the car after him. Joseph looked at her with his soft gaze, but it hid a glimpse of guilt behind it. Imaani was beautiful, and she had done nothing but love him unconditionally.

Looking up at the sky, Joseph ran his hands through his hair, whispering a 'thank you' to the gods above. He was grateful for the family he had. He was grateful for how far they had come. The hardships they had faced were not for the faint-hearted or the weakest of lovers. Right now, it was all rainbows and sunshine because they both vowed to leave it all behind and adore each other for the rest of their days. While Imaani strapped Mathew into the safety seat in the back, Joseph couldn't help but think of how scared he was when he almost lost her. He almost lost the woman of her dreams because of the things that never mattered. He admired her as she did nothing, just sat in the car and put on her seatbelt. Joseph couldn't decipher the pain she had gone through, yet she still *chose* him. And he would always be grateful for that.

"What?" Imaani asked, confused. "What are you waiting for?" she added with an awkward smile.

"Nothing," Joseph replied, shaking his head with a smile. "I adore you," he said as he leaned in and gave her a soft yet short kiss.

Imaani smiled against Joseph's lips. Mathew giggled excitedly, clapping his hands. He scrunched his button nose as Joseph poked it lovingly.

"Let's go to the beach!" Joseph proclaimed, and everyone cheered as they drove off.

All the flashbacks replayed in Joseph's head as he drove. The human mind was extraordinary; it only realized loss when it was too late. People didn't realize what they had until the timer ran out; the timer they set by overlooking the person they had and wandering around elsewhere to fill a void that doesn't need any attention or healing. Not in this case, though. Joseph had changed. And he was lucky enough to have Imaani, a woman who *chose* him through it all.

Chapter 2: High School Love

The week went by quickly. In a blink of an eye, Sunday morning turned into Thursday evening. The sky had burst into shades and tints of orange and pink as the Sun said its goodbyes. After a long day, Imaani finally came back home from her shift at the hospital. She wore a blue V-necked half-sleeved uniform and her hospital badge. As she set her big handbag on the couch, she was instantly greeted by Mathew, who came running towards her.

“Mommy!” he squealed.

“Hi, baby!” she smiled as she picked him up and spun him around.

Imaani kissed his cheek and looked around; Joseph was nowhere in sight.

“Where’s daddy?” Imaani asked.

Mathew giggled and shook his head.

“So, you’re on daddy’s side today, huh?” Imaani said, raising her eyebrows.

Mathew chuckled.

Imaani set him down and began to look around for Joseph, starting by going upstairs. As she walked closer to their room, her body stiffened when she heard him talking over the phone. She paused, contemplating whether she wanted to know who was on the other end of the line. After a few moments, she finally decided to knock. But before her petite hands could touch the wooden door, Joseph had already opened it. He took a step back out of fright, his hand on his heart as a smile spread across his face.

“You scared me,” he chuckled

Imaani was caught off-guard at first, not knowing how to react. Her stiff body relaxed as she smiled softly.

“I’m sorry.”

Joseph instantly knew why she was tensed and wrapped his arm around her. “It was a work call. They gave me another project.”

“I didn’t ask,” Imaani muttered, unable to look at him. She felt embarrassed.

“I wanted you to know,” assured Joseph, kissing her forehead. “And that’s so rude. Do you not care that your husband got a project?” he added, teasing her. His grip tightened as his fingers dug into her.

Imaani began squirming, laughing uncontrollably as he tickled her.

“I care! I care!” she managed to squeal out as she tried her best to get out of his grip, but it was no use.

“I can’t hear you,” Joseph joked, tickling her more.

Compared to him, she was tiny, a perfect fit in his arms, but also a curse when such a war broke out.

“I care! Please!” she begged, squirming as tears ran down her face. She couldn’t stop laughing, but her sides burned.

Joseph finally decided to stop, his arms still wrapped around her. Imaani fell loose onto his chest, heaving as she tried to catch her breath.

“Flashbacks,” he joked mischievously.

“Shut up. That’s out of pleasure. This was in pain,” she replied

“Sure.” Joseph scoffed, kissing her head as he picked her up and took her downstairs, where Mathew sat near the TV.

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August 2017:

“Who is she?!” shouted Imaani.

“I can explain. Baby, please, what you saw, it wasn’t-” Joseph tried to explain

“WHO. IS. SHE?!” Imaani screamed louder

The two of them stood right in front of their room. It was around two in the morning. Imaani had tears pooled up in her eyes as she stood against Joseph. Her hands were shaking, but her mouth was clenched shut in rage. Joseph, on the other hand, looked like a mixture of frustrated, guilty, and afraid.

The two stood in silence as their emotions clashed against one another. For Joseph, it felt like the end. This was it. And in that moment of silence, when Imaani glared her down with tears now flowing from her eyes.

He knew it; he was going to lose her. There was no way he could have explained what was happening. Without proof, he couldn't get Imaani to believe him. And that was causing this to worsen; the screams, the throwing things, the crying.

Maybe it was over.

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Thursday, May, 2022

Joseph leaned against the kitchen counter with his steaming mug of coffee in one hand. He thought about how Imaani stood against the door in fear. A sigh escaped his lips as he looked at the ground and shook his head. He ran a hand through his hair, guilt overlapping with relief that everything had changed. With his mug in one hand and laptop in the other, he made his way upstairs.

Usually, when Joseph worked, he liked to use the study in the basement, but today, he wanted to work in the spare room they had. He kept his things on the table and made his way out and back to his and Imaani's room.

It was dark. Imaani lay asleep under the sheets. Joseph made his way to her and kissed her forehead, then left to check on Mathew, who was also asleep in his room. Everything had changed, it was better, but there was a part of him that always wanted to make sure.

Joseph had changed his ways too. He chose to work on his projects at night when his family was asleep to spend time with them in the evenings. He wanted to make sure Imaani always knew that she was a choice he would make without even batting an eye and that anything he would do would be for his family. He would even lay with her until she fell asleep just so that she felt safe, just so she knew that she was all he ever wanted. But it was also just because he adored the conversations they had when she was half asleep.

A smile spread across Joseph's face as he sat himself in his study, recalling how Imaani kept telling him that she wanted lasagna tomorrow and a baby penguin. The combination made no sense, but then again, she was barely awake.

"I'll get you Lasagna."

"What about...the penguin?"

"Maybe."

Imaani frowned in her sleep with her eyes shut. "But...I want...one," she muttered.

"Okay," Joseph softly chuckled. "We'll get one."

The frown on Imaani's face slowly curved into a lazy smile that faded as Imaani dozed off in his arms.

It may seem childish, but he adored it. He adored everything. As he sat in his chair with his laptop open in front of him and began to work, he couldn't help but continuously think of the look on Imaani's face. He thought of how it was so similar to the fear she had five years ago. They had come such a long way from that point onwards. The sacrifices, the fights, the growth. Things would have been so different if he had chosen otherwise—if she had chosen something else.

Joseph began to recall the last five years, and within a matter of seconds, his train of thought began to spiral, and soon enough, he was thinking about high school again.

The first time he saw *her.*

Joseph was seventeen at the time. Tall, lean, with jet black hair and the perfect tan. He never really classified himself as good-looking, though. He thought he was average. He tended to mind his own business and keep his head low in school. Being the center of attention wasn't really his thing, but he did have some qualities that made him stand out. He was the smartest in class and one of the best players on the football team. Studies, parties, friends, and life in general were a good blend and, surprisingly, in balance.

Even though, Joseph may have seemed like he was one of the 'popular' kids, he never really associated himself with them. It was odd, though, knowing that he's an all-rounder yet not being a part of a clique. He was comfortable in his own skin. He liked his routine and always enjoyed getting the highest scores in his class. Every pop quiz, assessment, or test, he was always on top. He may not have come from a privileged family, keeping in mind that his dad was a mechanic and they weren't as well off as most people around the block. Still, he truly was an all-rounder, and his priorities were set.

On a cool Tuesday morning before football practice, Joseph sat in his seat as the teacher began to distribute last week's test papers. Usually, the teacher always called out Joseph's name, but this time, he didn't. Confused, he looked at his test sheet that lay upside down on his desk.

"Well done, Delilah," he heard his teacher say.

Joseph turned his test paper around, seeing that he had a 96.

"What-who...?" he muttered to himself as he turned out to see this Delilah girl.

All Joseph could think of was how she could get a higher score than him. Whoever she was, she was competition. That was until he saw her. She was one of the 'popular' kids; Joseph had seen her around. He thought she was very beautiful, with her long ashy brunette hair and hazel eyes. She was attractive, even when he didn't know her name. But what really attracted him was that she was smart too. He liked that.

Their eyes met, and he passed a smile at her. She returned the gesture and pointed at her paper, in a way, asking what his score was.

'You first,' mouthed Joseph. He was nervous. Joseph was a flirt by nature, but right now, he was being friendly. He was shy.

Delilah turned her paper for him to look. With squinted eyes, Joseph scoffed at her 97, making her giggle softly. He liked that. A smile spread across his face as she nodded towards his sheet. The bell rang, and he nodded towards the door teasingly. He wanted to get to know her more. And so, he did.

They walked out of class together. He handed Delilah his paper, to which she huffed.

"It's literally just a pointless. I should have done better."

Joseph was stunned at her playful response.

"Don't challenge me. I've always gotten the highest score. I was just lazy this time," he replied

"We'll see," she hummed, sounding determined. "Anyways, my class is the other way."

Joseph smiled at her, realizing that she had walked the opposite way just to talk to him, yet he didn't take it as more than a friendly gesture. All he knew was she was out of his league.

"I'm off to play football," replied Joseph. "See you tomorrow?"

He added, hoping to stay in touch.

"So that you can come second?" Joked Delilah once again

He scoffed and shook his head, "For *YOU* to come second," he corrected.

"We'll see," she said once again and turned the other way.

"We will," Joseph called after her with a smile.

Delilah turned around and waved at him. That did it; he instantly knew he liked her, but he also knew there was no way they could be more than friends. She was popular,

and he, well…he was just Joseph. He tried to shake the thought off as he walked to practice, but his first interaction with her stuck with Joseph.

He had met her. And he was hooked onto the thought of *her.*

Chapter 3: Prom

Joseph and Delilah grew closer as the days went by. The two of them were always competing to get the highest scores in class. Joseph would mostly win their little wagers, but there were times when he'd lose a point or two on purpose just so he could see her smile. Never did he imagine he would ever give up a grade for anyone—especially a *girl.* But, every time they had a quiz, and the moment his eyes would meet hers, a voice inside him told him that it was worth it. He felt it was the only way he could stay close to her.

The truth was, Joseph thought he had no chance with her. Even though Joseph, at the time, was considered objectively good-looking with his honey-brown eyes and charming smile. Most, if not all, the girls at school noticed him but were either too shy to approach him or had already been turned down by him.

When it came to Delilah, he had already made up his mind; she was a distant star, far from reach. In his mind, she was forbidden for two reasons. The first being that she was 'popular,' which meant she would never date a guy like her, or, at least, that's the narrative he fed himself. He believed he was just another guy in line, and he knew about all the guys at school that were crushing on her—which literally meant the whole team he was on. So, for him, it meant that he had no chance.

The other reason was that he was simply too scared to try now that they were good friends. So, he never tested his limits or made any moves on her. He was too scared of losing her. Over the past few months, they had gotten so close that he just couldn't risk their friendship. He was happy with the smile they'd pass one another across the hallway, the ten-minute conversations they'd share after class, and the light nudges when they teased one another. He was content and didn't mind it being one-sided either because he expected nothing from her. The fact that she would give him those ten minutes was well enough.

His eyes were on her and only her. That didn't mean he wasn't talking to other girls. After all, he was a flirt by nature. It just meant his heart was set on her. For him, it was more than just a crush; the closer they got, the stronger his feelings grew. It didn't

affect his life, though. He still did well in school and focused on football. It was as if life went on at its own pace, and the thought of *her* existed with it.

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The end of the school year was just right around the corner. Joseph was applying to colleges with his friend, Rose. It was that time of the year when only two things mattered; college acceptances and prom.

“Why aren’t you applying to any Ivy Leagues? You have the grades for it,” Rose said, accentuating her words with her eyebrows.

The two sat together, using the computer in the school library.

“I...don’t have the money,” he said, his eyes glued on the screen.

“Scholarships...” Rose hummed back.

Rose was in Joseph’s English and History class but she didn’t go to his school, it was a complicated case- she took some courses here and then other courses in another school. They had been friends since freshmen year. She was much shorter than him. Her skin was a beautiful shade of brown, her hair jet black with perfect coils, and her almond-shaped hazel eyes. She was petite and always smelt like a bottle of expensive yet elegant French perfume. She was a wallflower, quiet and kept to herself. In fact, Joseph was one of her only friends in school. Rose, too, was just as smart as Joseph. She was applying to the top colleges in the world. Joseph didn’t know why she didn’t have a lot of friends but never bothered asking why.

“Still can’t afford it,” Joseph said as he clicked the ‘confirm’ button on the screen. He sighed in relief as his final application went through the portal. He then turned to Rose with a flirtatious grin. “Pay for me?” he joked.

“Buy me dinner first,” Rose jokingly demanded.

Joseph lifted his brows, surprised by her response. His grin grew wider. “You’re learning.”

“Oh, shut up! I was joking!” she exclaimed as she slapped his arm.

A loud shush sounded from the other end of the library, which made the two of them sink in their seat. They tried to hold in their laughter, but light chuckles and giggles kept escaping their lips.

“You don’t know how hard it was to say that,” whispered Rose in between their giggles.

“I know you,” Joseph whispered back, snorting a little at the thought of it, “It looked like you were going to die of a heart attack,” he added with a chuckle.

“Shut up!” she yelled in a whisper as she tried to slap his arm again, but he moved it away and stuck his tongue out at her.

Their eyes met briefly before Joseph’s phone started to buzz. It was time for his ‘favorite’ class.

“Oh, shit! I’m going to be late,” he whispered as he got up and threw his bag over his shoulder. “See you, Rose,” he quickly said as he ruffled her hair and rushed out of the library.

“Hey!” Rose exclaimed, only to be hushed by the librarian once again.

Joseph was practically sprinting to class. He couldn’t afford to be late. This was one of the only moments he got to spend with *her*. He finally got to class, heaving and looked around, only to be greeted with the same smile that he loved. The seat next to her was empty, and he noticed how she had kept her bag on the chair so that no one else would sit there. The thought of it made his heart flutter and his stomach twist and turn in the weirdest way possible. He was pretty sure she could notice how red his face was, yet he hoped she didn’t.

Class went by swiftly, with the two of them occasionally scribbling on each other’s desks with pencils. Once the class had ended, Joseph waited for Delilah at the door, like he always did. The two of them stood in the halls.

“Prom’s next Friday. Who are you going to prom with?” Delilah casually asked as she leaned against one of the lockers nearby.

She wore a pastel blue skirt down to her knees, a white polo top, and sneakers. Her hair was straightened down and tied neatly in a low ponytail. Joseph liked how she dressed; it was never too much, but at the same time, it was never too less. Her makeup was never too much or too bold, it was soft, and it complimented her brown eyes at all times. Sometimes Joseph wished he could look into Delilah’s eyes, but it was difficult for him. He feared that she might find out.

“No one, you?” replied Joseph casually as he kicked the air, his hands stuffed in his pocket.

“You?”

Joseph’s heart skipped a beat, and he looked up at her.

“Me?”

She started laughing which made Joseph feel embarrassed. He thought she was asking him to prom but he shook the thought off instantly. He knew that wasn't a possibility and, in that moment, he felt dumb but he had to regain himself.

"Maybe," he forced out with an awkward chuckle.

A smile spread across Delilah's face at his response.

"Maybe?" she asked with a sheepish giggle.

"We'll see," he joked, forcing a huff.

There was a brief moment of silence between the both of them until they said their goodbyes and started walking in the opposite direction.

Delilah frowned a little to herself, this was probably the first time she had asked a guy to prom, and his response wasn't what she had expected. He seemed uninterested, but she tried not to take it to heart. She still tried to be optimistic about the situation and hoped that the little back and forth they had meant he would go to prom with her.

On the other hand, Joseph felt like he had made a fool out of himself for even thinking for a second that he had a chance with her. He was on his way to the field when he found Rose sitting near the entrance of the grounds. It was her usual spot and the same place they had met the first time. She was reading a book that day, and Joseph accidentally tripped over her. She immediately apologized to Joseph, being the way that he is; charmed his way into a friendship, and ever since, they had been friends.

He liked same. The two of them had very similar personalities. She was pretty and smart, a fun person to hang out with, and right now, Joseph needed a prom date. All these reasons raced through his mind as he made his way toward her.

"Hey!"

"Hey?" responded Rosie, completely confused as she got up.

He stopped right in front of her, practically towering over her.

"Who are you going to prom with?"

"What?" Rosie asked with her brows knitted.

"Prom? You and who?" He asked slower.

After a moment of silence, she looked up at him.

Joseph waited impatiently for her response, he hoped she would say yes, but the silence was just killing him.

As a response, Rose muttered something and looked down at the ground.

“What?” asked Joseph, his eyes squinted.

“I said...” Rose began and then muttered the rest, nervously rocking on her toes.

“What?” Joseph said with a light chuckle. He was nervous too, but mostly impatient. He needed an answer from her.

She sighed. “Buy me dinner first...” she forced out of herself.

A smile spread across Joseph’s face as he fist-bumped the air and jumped around.

“Joseph!” the coach yelled from the other side which made the two jump.

“Gotta go! Dinner it is, and THEN, prom!” he said quickly and raced off to the field.

A part of Joseph was still aching because of what had happened earlier, but he still chose to look at the brighter side of it all; he had a date, and it was someone he was comfortable with. He didn’t think much of it, though. It was a bit mixed for him. All he had to do was take her out for dinner, and then they were good to go.

After Joseph had left, Rose rushed into the school halls and into the girl’s bathroom; she locked the stall door behind her and leaned against the door. She began to process all that had happened. A light giggle escaped her lips, and she clasped her hand against her face. She was beyond excited, she never thought that Joseph would ever have asked her, and now she had something to look forward to.